From here on, the operation proceeded with absolute precision. Over most of Berlin and Brandenburg, the weather was beautiful in August 1961 – relentless sunshine poured over the city and forests. Everyday life was punctuated with trips to lidos, lakes and swimming baths. In this ocean of calm, Adam Kellet-Long, a duty reporter for Reuters in West Berlin, recalls a ‘vague feeling’ in the city that some action was pending to stop the refugee flow. In an interview for this book, he said it ‘would have been hard to avoid this feeling just from reading the East Berlin press and of course listening to West Berlin radio stations, something that the majority of the city’s population did’. However, Kellet-Long was certain that the populations of neither part of Berlin had any idea that the border would be closed, and a wall built:

And, as far as East Berlin was concerned, I can vouch from personal observation that the general population was not expecting anything drastic to happen that weekend. It was very hot, and a lengthy tour of East Berlin that Saturday afternoon showed the streets almost deserted as the population crowded public swimming pools and the lakes to cool off.

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As the light faded into the evening on 12 August, Ulbricht ordered members of the Politburo, the Presidium of the Council of Ministers, and the Council of State, to his summer residence on Döllnsee. Only Honecker, the Stasi, Defence and Transport Ministers were not present, for obvious reasons. After dinner, Ulbricht stunned his guests by reading out the resolution on the construction of the ‘anti-fascist protective wall’. There was no shock or delusory remarks, just grim nods of approval.

A few hours later, as the clock approached midnight, ‘Operation Rose’ commenced. ‘You know the assignment,’ Honecker told Army headquarters in a phone call, ‘Now March!’ As the army snapped into a state of high